

Modern period

With the disintegration of the harmonic certainties of the 19th century, composers struggled to create new approaches for their writing. As a result, many different directions were taken, some of enduring influence, some short-lived.

SEE ALSO

◀ 40–41 Syncopation and swing

◀ 108–109 Analyzing melodies

◀ 122–123 Diatonic and chromatic harmony

Popular music

222–223 ▶

Serialism

Devised by Arnold Schönberg (1874–1951), the expressionist technique of serialism uses each of an octave's 12 notes in a particular order, forming a "whole step row series." Melodies and chords are then created from this whole step row.

▽ Schönberg's Variations for Orchestra

Schönberg varies his original whole step row by inverting it (turning it upside down), using it backward (retrograde), or both (inverted retrograde).

The image displays four musical staves illustrating the 12-tone whole step row series and its transformations. The first staff, labeled 'Whole step row', shows the sequence of 12 notes (1 to 12) in a whole step pattern. The second staff, labeled 'Retrograde', shows the same sequence in reverse order (12 to 1). The third staff, labeled 'Inversion', shows the notes inverted (upside down). The fourth staff, labeled 'Retrograde inversion', shows the inverted sequence in reverse order. Each staff is numbered 1 through 12 below the notes.

Minimalism

A hypnotic-sounding musical style, minimalism is based on repetitive structures that change gradually. It was pioneered in San Francisco in the 1960s by composers including Steve Reich and John Adams.

▷ Ostinati

These rhythmic, melodic, or harmonic patterns are repeated, then fragmented, interlocked, or gradually changed.

▷ Syncopation and disrupted rhythm

Syncopation disrupts the rhythm by shifting the emphasis from the main beat to a subordinate beat.

▷ Broken chord

When repeated over a long period, the broken chord, or arpeggio, device is effective in creating a rippling, trance-like effect.

▷ Note addition and interlockings

Texture can be varied by adding an extra note to a pattern, or by changing the way in which different patterns interlock.

The image shows four musical staves illustrating various Minimalist techniques. The first staff, labeled 'Ostinato', shows a repeating rhythmic pattern in 3/4 time. The second staff, labeled 'Unsyncopated', shows a steady eighth-note pattern in 12/8 time. The third staff, labeled 'Syncopated', shows a pattern with accents on off-beats in 4/4 time. The fourth staff, labeled 'Chord of C major', shows a broken chord pattern in 4/4 time. The fifth staff, labeled 'Interlocking eighth-note patterns', shows two patterns interlocking in 4/4 time. The sixth staff, labeled 'Extra note added', shows a pattern with an additional note added in 4/4 time.